opportunity for a lasting peace in the Middle East. The longer the process dragged on, the harder it would be to achieve peace because of the growing influence of radical factions within the PLO. While moderate PLO leaders were likely to accept, however grudgingly, the reality of Israel, they were being challenged by PLO factions dominated by hard-line terrorists who would never accept it and would fight to the death to prevent it. Unless the Israelis left Lebanon soon and opened the way to a political settlement of the problems, Habib said, the Palestinian extremists would gain credibility among the Palestinian people and strengthen the hand of the radicals and their Islamic allies. If that happened, it was impossible to predict if there would be another solid chance for a long-term settlement of the problems.

I instructed Habib on his return to the Middle East to again tell Begin that Israel's intransigence might cost it its special relationship with America—and I crossed my fingers. King Hussein of Jordan, meanwhile, during a Washington visit, acknowledged that there were two sides to the Israeli-Arab conflict and indicated he was anxious to work with us to achieve a solution all parties could accept. "I really like him," I wrote in the diary after the visit. "He is our hope to lead the Arab side and the P.L.O. in negotiating with the Israelis. He has some problems in order to keep the trust of other Arab states and right now Israel is proving difficult. I told King Hussein that this was a top priority of mine and we'd go all out to bring peace in the Middle East and we'd stand by Jordan. . . ."

While King Hussein went to work on the Syrians, during the winter and early spring of 1982-83 we continued trying to persuade Menachem Begin to withdraw Israeli forces from Lebanon so that work on the broader peace process could resume and members of the multilateral force could go home. But he insisted that Israel had to keep its troops in